



US Economic Perspectives

May Beige Book pinpoints rising price pressures

We have previously leveraged our proprietary LLM tools to analyze the Beige Book, assessing economic sentiment across key macroeconomic variables: growth, the labor market, inflation, and perceived recession probabilities. In this piece we continued this exercise and updated our analysis for the latest Beige Book from May 2026.

Overall, the latest scores for the May Beige Book continue to signal a resilient growth outlook and a stable labor market, albeit with increasing upside risks to inflation. The report provided further indications of how the Middle East conflict and growing AI investment demand have impacted the economy, leading to strong activity growth in the manufacturing sector, emerging risks to consumer spending, and the risk of wage inflation, which could make the inflationary impact of energy shocks more persistent. While our baseline remains that the Fed is on hold indefinitely, the Beige Book revealed that recent demand-side forces and supply shocks point to rising risks of rate hikes being necessary to bring inflation back onto a more sustainable path towards 2% (see [US outlook Cliffs notes \(June 2026\)](#)).

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We have previously leveraged our proprietary LLM tools to analyze the Fed's Beige Book, assessing economic sentiment across key macroeconomic variables: growth, the labor market, inflation, and perceived recession probabilities (see [From qualitative to quantitative: decoding Beige Book with AI](#)). The derived sentiment scores were able to capture economic dynamics over the past decade. In this piece we continued this exercise and update our analysis for the latest Beige Book from May 2026.

As a reminder, the score is based on a scale of 0 to 10, a score of 0 is associated with a lower assessment of conditions, and a score of 10 is associated with higher assessment. A score of 5 is neutral (see Appendix for prompt for full details). Note that for the last topic on recession, a score of 0 would suggest that the recession is not expected in next 12 months, while a score of 10 would suggest that the recession is nearly certain in next 12 months. Our data spans from January 2015 to the latest Beige Book in May 2026.

While the latest Beige Book continued to reflect a stable labor market and healthy growth backdrop as observed in April, it offered more insights into the economic repercussions of the Middle East conflict and the surge in AI-driven investment. Specifically, the report highlighted robust hiring and activity growth within the manufacturing sector. However, it also pointed to clear inflation risks, primarily stemming from wage adjustments and the spill-over effects of energy-related costs. Concurrently, there is emerging weakness in some areas of consumption, attributed to affordability issues (see Figure 1-4).

The labor market score remained stable at a neutral level of 5, reflecting a low unemployment rate of 4.3% and a consistent pace of payroll gains in recent months (Figure 5). The Beige Book particularly emphasized robust hiring within the manufacturing sector, driven by defense-related activities and increasing demand for data centers. Furthermore, the report noted more frequent upward wage adjustments, which are a response to high oil prices and the rising cost of living. This trend could indicate potential risks of wage inflation and a more persistent inflationary impact from energy shocks.

Indeed, our inflation sentiment score increased from 7 to 8 in May, reaching its highest level since mid-2022, the peak of the COVID-19 driven inflation shocks. The May report indicated a clear intensification of price pressures compared to April, characterizing inflation as "moderate to strong", an upgrade from April's description of price growth as "mostly moderate." Both reports consistently identify energy-related costs stemming from the Middle East conflict as a primary driver, with broader impacts on freight, shipping, and various materials.

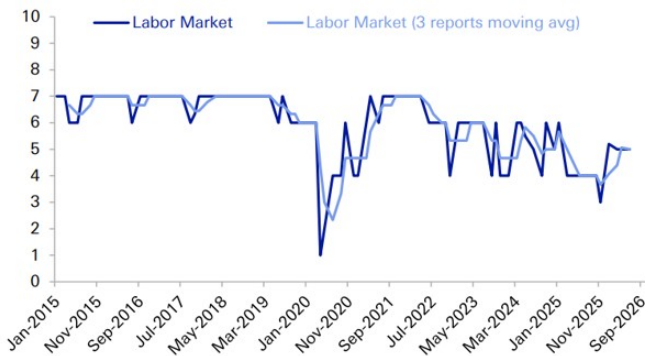
The growth sentiment score slightly decreased to 5, despite the May report indicating a broader base of moderate growth (10 districts) compared to April (8 districts), with manufacturing activity showing modest to strong growth. However, the latest report also extensively discussed the divergence in consumer spending, with middle- and lower-income households experiencing increased financial strains due to growing affordability pressures. Additionally, energy price spikes negatively impacted agricultural conditions. Given the elevated uncertainty weighing on both business and consumer sentiments, the recession score saw a modest increase from 4 in April to 6. This recession score has consistently exceeded our estimated probability for most of the sample period (Figure 8), which remains



at a historically low level near 10% (see [A post mortem on recession probability models](#)).

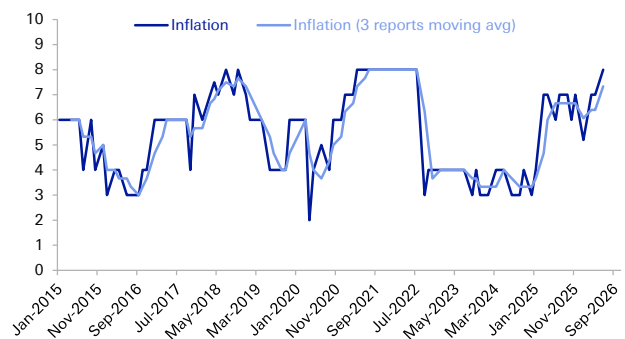
Overall, the latest scores for the May Beige Book continue to signal a resilient growth outlook and a stable labor market, albeit with increasing upside risks to inflation. The report provided further indications of how the Middle East conflict and growing AI investment demand have impacted the economy, leading to strong activity growth in the manufacturing sector, emerging risks to consumer spending, and the risk of wage inflation, which could make the inflationary impact of energy shocks more persistent. While our baseline remains that the Fed is on hold indefinitely, the Beige Book revealed that recent demand-side forces and supply shocks point to rising risks of rate hikes being necessary to bring inflation back onto a more sustainable path towards 2% (see [US outlook Cliffs notes \(June 2026\)](#)).

Figure 1: Labor market score stayed at neutral level



Source : Federal Reserve Banks, Deutsche Bank Research

Figure 2: Inflation score rose to highest since 2022



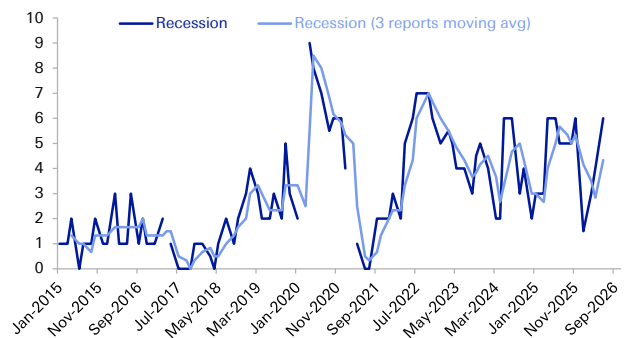
Source : Federal Reserve Banks, Deutsche Bank Research

Figure 3: Growth score at neutral despite increasing downside risks



Source : Federal Reserve Banks, Deutsche Bank Research

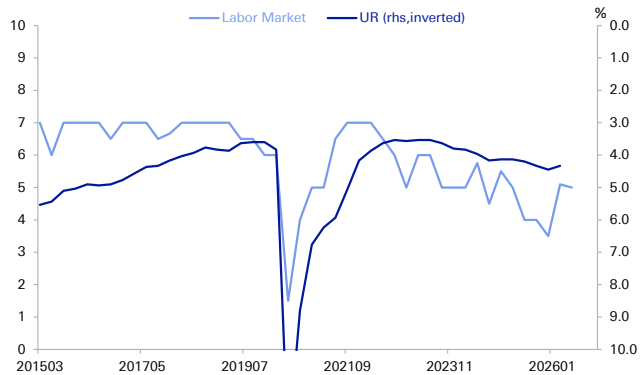
Figure 4: Recession concerns rose further from the Middle East conflicts



Source : Federal Reserve Banks, Deutsche Bank Research

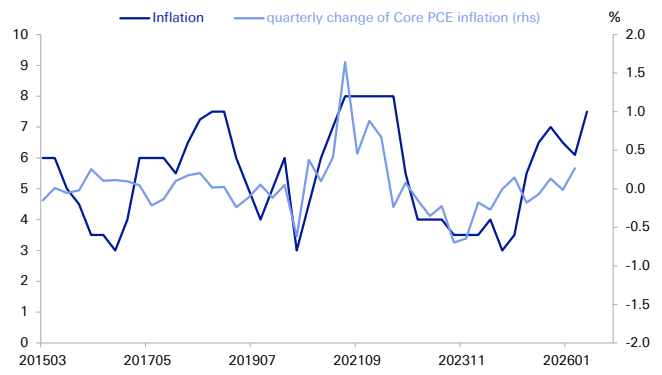


Figure 5: Labor market stabilized and roughly in balance



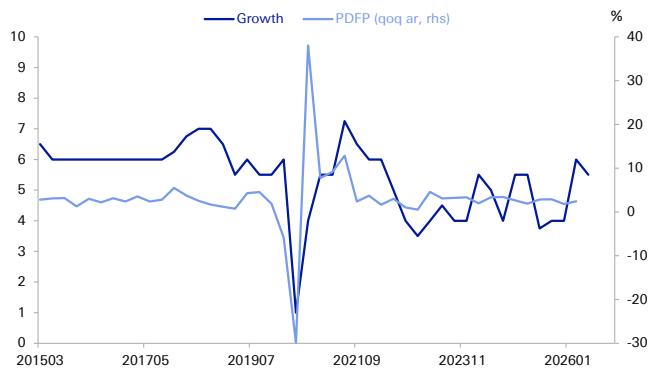
Source : Federal Reserve Banks, Deutsche Bank Research

Figure 6: Inflation pressures intensified



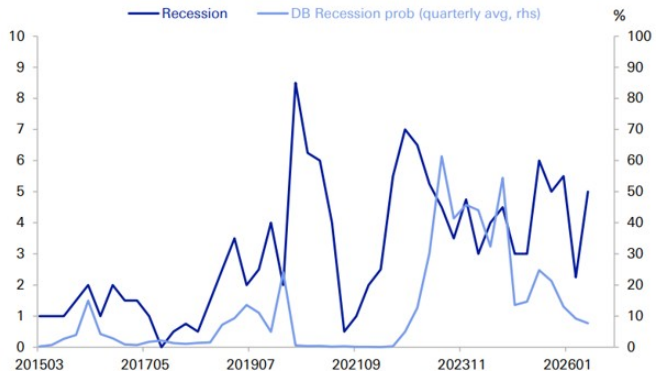
Source : Federal Reserve Banks, Deutsche Bank Research

Figure 7: Growth sentiment softened



Source : Federal Reserve Banks, Deutsche Bank Research

Figure 8: Recession probabilities at low level despite weaker sentiment



Source : Federal Reserve Banks, Deutsche Bank Research



Appendix 1

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